

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Manufacturing English

Teacher's guide

Teach practical workplace communication with specific cases, clear language targets, and a repeatable feedback process.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Find the right language. Speak, write, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For plant managers, production supervisors, quality engineers, maintenance teams, industrial engineers, safety leads, supply planners, and manufacturing-adjacent professionals.

These cases practice communication. Actual equipment, construction, and safety work follows approved procedures and authorized specialist decisions.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Your course at a glance

Use the lesson numbers to match this document with the website and the other guides.

01 Production Flow and Daily Management

Distinguish completed work from pending work and explain its impact.

02 Lean, Waste, and Continuous Improvement

Describe observed behavior, its effect, and a useful next step.

03 Defects, Scrap, and Rework

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

04 Root Cause and Corrective Action

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

05 Maintenance, Reliability, and Changeover

Negotiate scope or timing while making conditions explicit.

06 EHS and Safety Communication

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

07 Supplier Quality and Incoming Materials

Clarify missing information before responding.

08 Shift Handoffs and Escalation

Give a handoff that the receiving person can confirm.

Choose your pace

Quick practice: spend 15 minutes reading one case and saying a response. Full lesson: allow 45-60 minutes for language work, conversation, writing, and revision.

Level support

B1 learners can use the frames and a partner. B2 learners can try a response before reading the model. C1 learners can add the harder follow-up and reduce preparation time. These are teaching suggestions, not certified CEFR level ratings.

After practicing: open the AI prompt workshop, or use the prompts at the end of this guide.

A 60-minute lesson that works

Prepare the case and the learner pages. Keep the model response hidden until learners have attempted their own. Choose two field terms that are important to understanding the case.

0-5 minutes | Activate experience

Ask learners to name a comparable situation without sharing confidential details. Introduce the communication goal.

5-12 minutes | Read and sort facts

Read the case. Learners identify confirmed facts, unknowns, the audience, and the immediate communication need.

12-22 minutes | Notice and practice language

Explain the workshop pattern. Work through the vocabulary and editing example, then discuss both language checks and the reasons behind the choices.

22-35 minutes | Speak and respond

Give two minutes of preparation. Run the partner exchange, switch roles, and add the follow-up challenge. Observe whether the listener can act on the message.

35-47 minutes | Write for a real reader

Learners write the short message using only case facts. Partners check clarity, certainty, and the requested next step.

47-55 minutes | Compare and revise

Reveal the model. Discuss alternative acceptable wording. Give one meaning correction and one language correction, then repeat.

55-60 minutes | Retrieve and transfer

Close the materials. Learners recall two expressions and identify one communication habit to use in another situation.

Adapt the session

For 45 minutes, shorten the first conversation and assign writing for follow-up. For 90 minutes, add 15 minutes for a second case and 15 minutes for the final challenge. More time should produce more meaningful practice, not longer explanations.

LESSON 01 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Production Flow and Daily Management

Distinguish completed work from pending work and explain its impact.

CASE

A production line made 840 units against a 1,000-unit target. The log records 40 minutes of downtime; its cause is still being checked.

Teach this move

Lead with the current state, then the important change or open item. Use completed-action language only for completed work. Add a next update point when it is known; do not invent a date to make the message sound complete.

Vocabulary to check: throughput, cycle time, constraint, downtime.

Model response

Output was 160 units below target, and the log shows 40 minutes of downtime. We have not confirmed the cause. I'll include the downtime review in the next production update.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision gives observable progress. A positive label alone does not tell the reader what is complete or still needed.

Second-round challenge

The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

Language-check answers

1. B - The team has completed the review. 'Has completed' states that the action is finished.
2. A - Delivery is planned for Friday; the carrier has not confirmed it. This explicitly labels the date as planned and identifies the missing confirmation.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 02 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Lean, Waste, and Continuous Improvement

Describe observed behavior, its effect, and a useful next step.

CASE

A team observes repeated waiting for shared tools during a kaizen event. A supervisor blames slow operators.

Teach this move

Use a specific example instead of a personality label. Explain its effect, invite the person's perspective, and agree on a practical improvement. Focus on communication that can be changed, not accent or national identity.

Vocabulary to check: kaizen, standard work, waste, value stream.

Model response

The observed delay occurs while people wait for shared tools. Let's examine tool availability and layout before attributing the issue to individual speed. Could we test a revised arrangement?

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision identifies observable work. 'Always' and a personality judgment make the feedback harder to verify or act on.

Second-round challenge

The recipient disagrees with your interpretation. Return to the observed example, listen, and revise an unsupported assumption.

Language-check answers

1. A - The last two updates omitted the agreed completion date. The recipient can check the specific examples and discuss how to improve them.
2. C - What is making this part of the task difficult? An open question may reveal a barrier the speaker has not considered.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 03 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Defects, Scrap, and Rework

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

CASE

A quality report combines scrapped units with units awaiting rework. The manager needs to understand the different consequences.

Teach this move

Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

Vocabulary to check: defect, scrap, rework, containment.

Model response

Scrap and rework are different outcomes. Scrapped units will not return to the process as usable product; rework attempts to make units conform. I'll report their quantities separately.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revised sentence names the action in familiar words. Specialist vocabulary is useful when it adds precision, but repeating abstract nouns can hide the meaning.

Second-round challenge

Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Language-check answers

1. C - The backlog is the work still waiting to be completed. This gives the meaning in familiar words.
2. B - How would you describe the next step in your own words? An open request lets the listener show their understanding.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 04 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Root Cause and Corrective Action

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

CASE

A defect appears after a supplier change, but several process settings also changed. A team member names the supplier as the root cause.

Teach this move

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Vocabulary to check: root cause, 5 Whys, fishbone, 8D.

Model response

The timing makes the supplier change worth examining, but other settings changed too. It is a hypothesis, not an established root cause. Let's compare the evidence before closing the investigation.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision states the finding and its scope. It avoids turning limited evidence into a universal claim.

Second-round challenge

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Language-check answers

1. B - The change may have contributed to the delay. 'May have contributed' presents a possibility without claiming the cause is established.
2. A - In this pilot, the observed result was ... This locates the finding in the setting actually studied.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 05 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Maintenance, Reliability, and Changeover

Negotiate scope or timing while making conditions explicit.

CASE

A planned maintenance window conflicts with a rush order. The maintenance team needs to explain the available options to the decision maker.

Teach this move

Acknowledge the goal and explain the available choices. Connect an offer to its actual conditions. A useful response makes room for discussion without promising approval or resources you do not control.

Vocabulary to check: preventive maintenance, MTBF, changeover, spare parts.

Model response

The rush order and maintenance window compete for the same equipment. Could we review the approved options, expected production impact, and reliability concerns together before changing the plan?

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. For an ordinary future condition, the "if" clause uses present tense. The other clause can express the future consequence or possibility.

Second-round challenge

The preferred option is unavailable. Offer an alternative and clearly state any approval still needed.

Language-check answers

1. A - If the scope changes, we will review the schedule. The "if" clause uses present tense; the main clause states the future response.
2. C - We can assess the addition and explain its effect on the agreed scope. This offers a useful next step while keeping the approval and scope question open.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 06 / FACILITATOR NOTES

EHS and Safety Communication

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

CASE

During a safety exercise, a learner notices an unclear equipment-isolation instruction. The local approved procedure must govern the work.

Teach this move

State the action and the information needed. Explain why it matters and specify a deadline only when one is given or agreed. 'Could you' is polite; repeated apologies can obscure a legitimate request. Urgent situations may require a direct request.

Vocabulary to check: EHS, lockout/tagout, near miss, stop work.

Model response

I need clarification of this instruction before the task proceeds. Please involve the authorized person and use the approved safety procedure. I will point out exactly which instruction is unclear.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision names the document and requested response. It avoids expressions that may be unfamiliar or ambiguous for an international audience.

Second-round challenge

The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

Language-check answers

1. C - Send it no later than Thursday. 'By' sets the latest point, while 'after' refers to a later time.
2. B - Could you confirm the document version needed for the review? The requested action and information are explicit.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 07 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Supplier Quality and Incoming Materials

Clarify missing information before responding.

CASE

An incoming inspection report cites a dimension without identifying the drawing revision. The supplier used a different revision.

Teach this move

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Vocabulary to check: supplier quality, incoming inspection, specification, deviation.

Model response

Which drawing revision applies to this delivery? Let's record both references and ask the responsible quality team to resolve the discrepancy before we describe the material as conforming.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. After an introductory phrase such as 'Could you explain', the embedded question uses statement word order: "what this means".

Second-round challenge

The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Language-check answers

1. B - Could you confirm when the review starts? The embedded question uses subject then verb: "the review starts".
2. A - Has the report been approved, or is it ready for review? This question distinguishes two meanings of 'ready' that affect the next action.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 08 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Shift Handoffs and Escalation

Give a handoff that the receiving person can confirm.

CASE

The outgoing shift has completed six of eight checks. Two checks remain open, with records attached and a named incoming supervisor.

Teach this move

State the current situation, relevant background, open task, and receiving role. Ask for acknowledgment or repeat-back of the critical item. Sending a message and transferring responsibility are not always the same thing.

Vocabulary to check: handoff, andon, escalation, owner.

Model response

Six checks are complete; two remain open. The records show what has been checked and what is pending. Please confirm that the incoming supervisor has accepted the follow-up tasks.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revised sentence asks for an identifiable receiving team instead of leaving responsibility with an unspecified 'someone'.

Second-round challenge

The intended recipient cannot take ownership. Keep the status clear and identify the need for an authorized reassignment.

Language-check answers

1. A - Please confirm who will complete the outstanding check. It asks for an identifiable person or team responsible for the task.
2. C - So the result is pending and your team will follow up; is that correct? This repeats the status and responsibility and invites correction.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and writes a 70-110 word message. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

These cases practice communication. Actual equipment, construction, and safety work follows approved procedures and authorized specialist decisions.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.

Extend your practice with AI

Use the next two prompts after your own first attempt. Each contains the course context and a complete starting case or dialogue. Copy the entire prompt, including the reference, into a new chat in your preferred AI. You can also use the links to copy it from the website.

Choose the right kind of help

A role-play prompt makes the AI wait for your replies. A new-dialogue prompt asks for a complete professional script. Writing feedback begins with your draft. Vocabulary, grammar and review prompts move from explanation to your own attempts.

Choose any lesson or dialogue online

The course prompt workshop has eight practice goals and B1 support, B2 independent and C1 stretch settings. These are practice choices, not assessed proficiency levels. Select the same lesson number or dialogue title you used in this guide.

[Open this course's AI prompt workshop](#)

Keep practice useful

Use fictional or anonymized details. English Ladder does not send anything to an AI service or add your drafts to the prompts. Your chosen service's terms and any usage charges apply. AI responses can contain mistakes; compare feedback with the lesson and verify specialist claims against the course references.

The two starter prompts use B2 practice. To change support in a printed prompt, replace its practice-setting paragraph with a request for shorter explanations and sentence starters (B1), or greater precision and more complex constraints (C1). Keep the professional facts unchanged.

Changing the example

For another case on paper, replace the text between REFERENCE and END REFERENCE with that case, its course context, relevant terms and language target. Include the full exchange if practicing a dialogue. Do not assume your AI can access this PDF or a link. The website makes this substitution for you.

Prompt edition: 2026-09-06. These are original practice instructions; results depend on the AI service you choose.

Adapt a partner or class activity

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Manufacturing English

Professional audience: plant managers, production supervisors, quality engineers, maintenance teams, industrial engineers, safety leads, supply planners, and manufacturing-adjacent professionals

Scope: These cases practice communication. Actual equipment, construction, and safety work follows approved procedures and authorized specialist decisions.

Lesson 01: Production Flow and Daily Management

Original fictional case: A production line made 840 units against a 1,000-unit target. The log records 40 minutes of downtime; its cause is still being checked.

Language workshop: Give a useful status update

Communication goal: Distinguish completed work from pending work and explain its impact.

Language guidance: Lead with the current state, then the important change or open item. Use completed-action language only for completed work. Add a next update point when it is known; do not invent a date to make the message sound complete.

Useful frames (complete the gaps with case facts): We have completed ...; ... remains open. / As of ..., the status is / The next update will cover

Vocabulary: throughput: Amount of work, patients, goods, cases, or transactions completed in a period of time. / cycle time: The time needed to complete one defined production or work cycle. / constraint: A limit that restricts the available choices or amount of work possible. / downtime: Time during which equipment or a service is unavailable for its intended work.

Speaking task: Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to brief someone who has only one minute. Ask what is complete, what is open, and which open item affects the next action.

Writing task: Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Optional second-round challenge: The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

Model for comparison AFTER my attempt, not a response to give me first: Output was 160 units below target, and the log shows 40 minutes of downtime. We have not confirmed the cause. I'll include the downtime review in the next production update.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Adapt this material for a teaching session

1. Ask me one brief planning question covering learner support needs, group size and available time. Offer a default of two B2 learners and 20 minutes. Stop and wait; use the default only if I choose it.
2. Create a timed plan using the supplied case or dialogue, its actual terminology and one narrow language goal. Include an individual first attempt, partner exchange, focused feedback and a retry. Keep the total within the time I choose. State what the learner should be able to communicate at the end.
3. Provide separate role cards for two or three professional speakers. Each card needs an objective, known information and one question to resolve. Label any invented private information as a variation; do not contradict shared facts. Do not place the model answer on the learner cards.
4. Add a B1 support option with useful frames, a B2 independent task and a C1 extension involving a plausible competing constraint. Maintain the same professional meaning across levels. Explain unfamiliar terms without removing the field's normal language. Include a workable solo alternative.
5. Put teacher notes and suggested responses in a clearly separate section after the learner material. Include likely misunderstandings and a short observation checklist for facts, clarity, tone and next step. Accept multiple successful formulations. Finish with one exit question and a delayed-recall task; identify what the teacher should check before use.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level

Adjust tone and register

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

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Optional second-round challenge: The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

Model for comparison AFTER my attempt, not a response to give me first: Output was 160 units below target, and the log shows 40 minutes of downtime. We have not confirmed the cause. I'll include the downtime review in the next production update.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Match the language to the listener

1. Choose a short message or utterance from the reference and quote it exactly. Identify its purpose and likely audience. Ask me to choose a new audience: a close colleague, a decision-maker, or an external reader who may not know the jargon. Stop and wait.
2. Ask me to adapt that message for the chosen reader, keeping its facts and degree of certainty unchanged. Offer a short frame only if I request help. Wait for my attempt before showing alternatives.
3. Discuss at most three choices in my version: directness, specialist vocabulary and interpersonal tone. Explain when a direct request is clearer than extra politeness, and when an unfamiliar abbreviation needs expansion. Avoid cultural stereotypes or claims that one nationality always communicates a certain way.
4. Show two natural alternatives, such as a concise spoken version and a more explicit written version. Explain the tradeoff in each. Do not turn a request into an order, a possibility into a promise, or a pending decision into approval.
5. Ask me to respond to one realistic follow-up from the new reader, then wait. Finish by asking me to adapt the message for a second audience without losing its core meaning. Give feedback only after the attempt.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level